

1939–1949

If this period is known for the moment India got its independence, it also marks the immense violence that followed the partition of the subcontinent. Trains carried masses of humanity across borders, but also became sites of brutality and bloodlust. Everything was divided, even a railway network that once united a country. As a young, free India took stock, it realized that its truncated railway network was in a bad shape. It was now time to integrate and rebuild.

1939 Nazi Germany invades Poland, forcing France and Britain to declare war on Germany on 3 September, starting World War II. 1939 The Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose experiments with diesel railcars. 23 March 1940 The resolution demanding the creation of Pakistan is passed at the All-India Muslim League in Lahore.	17 October 1940 The Individual Civil Disobedience campaign is started by Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. The campaign would come to an end by 1941.	July 1942 A flash flood wipes out the tracks on Chapparghat. This route to Quetta is abandoned. August 1942 The Quit India movement begins.	1942 A famine rages across Bengal, eventually claiming more than three million lives. 1943 The State takes over the Bengal and North Western Railway, merging several other companies to form the Gujrat and Tindhur Railway.	1 October 1944 The Bengal-Nagpur Railway is taken over by the Government.	2 September 1945 World War II comes to an end after Japan surrenders. October 1945 India, not an independent nation yet, becomes one of the founding members of the United Nations. 1945 The Tata Engineering and Locomotive Co. (TELCO) is formed.	6 December 1946 A Constituent Assembly is elected to write the Indian Constitution. 17 August 1947 The new borders of India and Pakistan are declared and an exodus of refugees begins. Vast networks of the Bengal Assam Railway and North Western Railway are now in Pakistan. 30 January 1948 Gandhi is assassinated.	1948 The state of Israel is established, marking the beginning of the Israel-Palestine conflict. 1949 The Railway Board adopts all-steel construction as a standard for coaches.	
1939–40		1941–43		1944 – 45		1946–47		1948–49
1939–45 Railways in India feel the strain of the war as workshops start making military equipment and rolling stock is taken to the Middle East. 1940s All-steel broad-gauge coaches are manufactured for the first time in India. 1939 Subhas Chandra Bose creates the Forward Bloc.	7 December 1941 A Japanese aerial attack on Pearl Harbour marks the U.S. entry into World War II.	March 1942 Seeking active cooperation in British war efforts, the Cripps Mission comes to India with a promise of dominion status. 1942 Most of the remaining large railway companies are taken over by the Government.	February 1943 Howrah Bridge opens, allowing the trains to connect to the Howrah route.	1944–45 The Madras & Southern Mahratta and South Indian Railway Company lines are merged and the Government takes over operations.	1945 The first all-electric interlocking is put into place at the Bandra station, Bombay. 1945 Indian Railway Standards becomes Indian Government Railway Standards. 4 August 1945 The US drops an atomic bomb on Hiroshima and three days later, on Nagasaki.	November 1947 First interim Railway Budget speech is made in free India. 1948 The Assam Re-linking Project to connect it to the rest of the country via railways begins.	1948 100 WG class 2-B-2 locomotives are ordered from the North British Locomotive Company, the start of this successful class in India. 1949 The Gokuldas's Baroda State Railway and the Bombay, Baroda and Central India (BB&CI) are merged even as the Rajasthan Government takes over the Jodhpur-Bikaner Railway.	26 November 1949 The Constitution of India is adopted.
 A report on the bombing of Poland and the start of World War II  People lining for food in Calcutta, 1943  Bombing of Nagasaki, Japan  Refugees migrating to India during Partition  A locomotive built for India by Baldwin Locomotive Works								

“If they were in India, where on earth was Pakistan? And if they were in Pakistan, then how come that until only the other day it was India?”

SAADAT HASAN MANTO, IN HIS SHORT STORY “TOBA TEK SINGH” (1955)